

Chapter 2: The Man Who Wanted Her Fired

The restaurant was silent.

Customers stopped eating.

Employees stopped moving.

Everyone stared at the strand of hair dangling between Austin Blackwood's fingers.

Jenny's heart sank.

She knew this scene.

A customer complained.

Management apologized.

Someone got blamed.

Usually the employee.

Madam Chen hurried out of the kitchen.

"What seems to be the problem, Mr. Blackwood?"

Austin lifted the strand of hair.

"I found this in my food."

Madam Chen examined it carefully.

Then she nodded.

"I sincerely apologize. We will replace your meal immediately."

Austin's expression didn't change.

"That's not enough."

The room grew even quieter.

"What would you like us to do?" Madam Chen asked.

Austin looked directly at Jenny.

"Fire her."

A gasp spread through the restaurant.

Jenny froze.

Did he really just say that?

Madam Chen frowned.

"Mr. Blackwood, Jenny is one of our best employees."

"Then perhaps your standards are too low."

Jenny felt heat rise in her chest.

She had worked at Golden Dragon for nearly five years.

Five years of double shifts.

Five years of carrying trays until her arms ached.

Five years of helping keep the restaurant running.

And this stranger thought she deserved to lose her job because of a single hair?

Madam Chen folded her arms.

"She will not be fired."

Austin's eyes narrowed.

"Interesting."

"No employee deserves to lose their livelihood over one mistake."

"What if it wasn't a mistake?" Austin asked.

Jenny finally spoke.

"What exactly are you accusing me of?"

Austin turned toward her.

His gaze was cold.

"You served the food."

"I didn't cook it."

"You brought it to my table."

"And?"

"And the hair appeared."

Jenny stared at him.

Then she laughed.

A short, disbelieving laugh.

Several customers looked shocked.

Apparently nobody laughed at Austin Blackwood.

"Do you think I personally placed a hair in your noodles?" she asked.

His jaw tightened.

"I think someone was careless."

Jenny took a step closer.

"And you think that someone is me."

"Yes."

She shook her head.

"You must have a very easy life."

The room became painfully quiet.

Austin blinked.

"What did you say?"

Jenny crossed her arms.

"I said you must have a very easy life."

Madam Chen whispered urgently.

"Jenny..."

But Jenny continued.

"Most people have real problems."

Austin stared at her.

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"Real problems?"

"Like paying rent."

Another step.

"Buying medicine."

Another step.

"Feeding their families."

Now they stood only a few feet apart.

"And then there are people who treat a strand of hair like a national emergency."

A customer nearly choked on his tea.

Bao turned away to hide a laugh.

Austin looked furious.

Yet oddly fascinated.

Nobody spoke to him like this.

Nobody.

Not employees.

Not business partners.

Not even competitors.

But this tiny waitress with messy dark hair and oversized glasses seemed completely fearless.

Or completely crazy.

He wasn't sure which.

Madam Chen stepped between them.

"Enough."

She turned to Austin.

"We will refund your meal."

Austin reached into his coat.

He placed several silver coins on the table.

Far more than the meal cost.

"I don't need a refund."

Then he looked at Jenny one last time.

For a moment, neither spoke.

The tension between them was impossible to ignore.

Finally, Austin said quietly,

"You have a remarkable attitude for someone in your position."

Jenny didn't look away.

"And you have a remarkable ego for someone with a hair in his soup."

Several customers burst into laughter.

Austin's face darkened.

Without another word, he turned and walked out.

The front door slammed behind him.

The entire restaurant exhaled.

At once.

Bao rushed over.

"Jenny! Have you completely lost your mind?"

"What?"

"You insulted Austin Blackwood!"

"He insulted me first."

"That's Austin Blackwood!"

Jenny rolled her eyes.

"So people keep telling me."

Madam Chen rubbed her forehead.

"I need tea."

"Sorry," Jenny said.

The older woman looked at her.

"No, you're not."

Jenny smiled.

"Not really."

Madam Chen sighed.

"Go take your break before you start another war."

A few minutes later, Jenny sat alone behind the restaurant.

The night air was cool.

For the first time all evening, she could breathe.

Her phone buzzed.

A message from her mother.

Jenny's smile faded as she read it.

Her father's medicine costs had increased again.

The harvest had failed.

Money was becoming a problem.

Again.

Jenny stared at the screen.

She only had enough savings for a few more months.

After that...

She didn't know.

The weight of responsibility settled on her shoulders.

As always.

A sudden voice interrupted her thoughts.

"You look different when you're not arguing."

Jenny nearly dropped her phone.

She looked up.

Standing at the end of the alley was Austin Blackwood.

His hands were in his pockets.

His expression unreadable.

Jenny frowned.

"What are you doing here?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

As if he were asking himself the same question.

Then he said something neither of them expected.

"I think we got off on the wrong foot."

Jenny stared.

For the first time that night, she was speechless.

And Austin Blackwood almost smiled.